valuation. We are serious about disinvesting them, and will find an opportune time to do so.

Q. Disinvestment is also a political hot potato. Are you concerned about the backlash from trade unions of the companies on the privatisation list?

Constantly putting that argument forward doesn't augur well. In Air India's case, consultations with the trade unions went on till the last minute. Tell me, after giving it over to a private bidder, has anyone been removed from a job? If anything, they have been given increased responsibility. And whoever has wanted to leave has been given a handshake that they couldn't even have imagined. So, when we are disinvesting, we are not unmindful or uncaring about the requirements of the people working there. Trade unions today are very realistic. They know what they are in for. They want the unit to be working, running and making profits. They want those institutions to work. They do not want them closed. So, our disinvestment is not for closing them. They are for selling them out as growing firms and their jobs are going to continue.

Q. What about asset monetisation? There are areas where not much progress seems to have been made.

In real estate, REITs (real estate investment trusts) and InvITs (infrastructure investment trusts) are two new tools of investments that have successfully managed to keep that sector alive. Today, real estate is doing well because there is demand and inventory too is getting cleared. Today, in the real estate sector, we work together with the states, and state governments have also conveniently changed registration stamp duties. Maharashtra, in particular, has done brilliant work, as a result of which all inventory has been cleared.

Q. Will the other areas of asset monetisation be taken up with more gusto?

We have to move on them, there's no doubt. The decision of the cabinet cannot be negotiated or disputed. But when and what is the opportune moment for doing that is the question.

Q. Manufacturing has remained stagnant with a contribution of just around 15 per cent to the economy on an average. Don't we need to kick it up to at least 20 per cent for jobs to grow?

I'm not even fixing a number. Manufacturing will have to grow. What model it has to take is a different story. Some would say "Copy China". Some would say don't do so. India will have to be *aatmanirbhar* (self-reliant) on many things it consumes, which the country is capable of producing. We need to prioritise things that we are currently importing but, eventually, it shouldn't stop there. It should expand to include other things as well. You need to have some manufacturing base without doubt.

"Do you think throwing one lakh rupees, as the Congress promises, will meet a person's medical requirements, education, having a house or getting drinking water?"

"PM Modi's vision is to make everyone create wealth for themselves. If people can earn on their own, save on their own, buy property, that itself lifts them to the next level"

Q. What more can be done for the MSME (micro, small and medium enterprises) sector, which is a major engine of growth?

I don't want to begin by saying we've done a lot. But we have done a lot for MSMEs—changing their definition, giving them loans within 59 minutes on the ticker. They have to just go register and say this is the amount they want, and the approval comes within the 59th minute. Post that, they can always avail of the details. Sidbi (Small Industries Development Bank of India) has been given more and more money to finance MSMEs directly. I've sat with Sidbi to say there are some 300 clusters of MSMEs in this country, you should be present in most of them, physically. We've asked them to open branches in each of these clusters and where they cannot because of distance or something else, they deal with them online. Other than this, the 45-day payment—they said nobody is paying us (our dues) within 45 days. It had been an MSME law since 2008 or 2006. Nobody was obeying it. We made sure that payment is made within 45 days so that their monies were not locked up. For MSMEs, we are constantly sitting and listening to them and taking their suggestions forward. We'll continue to do that.

Q. Coming to Modi 3.0. What are the things we can look forward to if your party gets a third term?

The emphasis on infrastructure will continue. There will be a lot more access to different regions that even now are far-flung. The digital infrastructure will certainly be ramped up. Education, health will continue to see the concern they have been getting in the past few years. Skilling—we need people to be ready as soon as they finish their university courses to